

Arthritis Meal Planning UK: Weekly Menus for Joint Health

Practical weekly meal plans for arthritis. Budget-friendly UK recipes following the Mediterranean diet with anti-inflammatory foods to support joint health.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-04 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk



*Person planning healthy meals with fresh vegetables and a notebook in a bright kitchen
Openly licensed image via Openverse*

Knowing that an anti-inflammatory diet helps arthritis is one thing — actually planning and preparing meals each week is quite another. This guide provides practical, budget-friendly meal plans specifically designed for people with arthritis in the UK,

using ingredients readily available in British supermarkets. Each recipe is designed to be simple, requiring minimal chopping and preparation — because we know that hand and wrist pain can make cooking a challenge.

Principles of Arthritis Meal Planning

- Anti-inflammatory focus — Centre meals around vegetables, fruits, whole grains, lean protein and healthy fats
 - Omega-3 priority — Include oily fish at least twice per week
 - Colourful plates — Different colours represent different antioxidants. Aim for the rainbow
 - Batch cooking — Cook larger portions and freeze in individual servings for difficult days
 - Simple preparation — Minimal chopping, one-pot meals and traybakes reduce hand strain
 - Budget-friendly — Anti-inflammatory eating doesn't need to be expensive. Tinned fish, frozen vegetables, lentils and seasonal produce keep costs down
-

Sample Week 1: Winter Menu



Openly licensed image via Openverse

Monday

- Breakfast — Overnight oats with frozen berries, walnuts and a drizzle of honey (prepare the night before — no morning effort needed)
- Lunch — Tinned sardines on wholemeal toast with sliced tomato and a handful of rocket
- Dinner — One-pot chicken and vegetable stew with sweet potato (simply chop everything into a pot with stock and simmer for 45 minutes)

Tuesday

- Breakfast — Live yoghurt with a handful of mixed nuts and a sprinkle of cinnamon
- Lunch — Lentil and vegetable soup (batch cook on Sunday and reheat). Wholemeal bread roll

- Dinner — Baked salmon fillets with roasted Mediterranean vegetables (courgette, peppers, cherry tomatoes, olive oil — all on one tray, 20 minutes)

Wednesday

- Breakfast — Porridge with grated fresh ginger, a banana and flaxseeds
- Lunch — Hummus, roasted vegetable and spinach wholemeal wrap
- Dinner — Bean and vegetable chilli with brown rice (use tinned beans and passata for ease)

Thursday

- Breakfast — Scrambled eggs on wholemeal toast with a handful of cherry tomatoes
- Lunch — Leftover bean chilli (from yesterday) with an avocado side salad
- Dinner — Grilled mackerel with new potatoes and steamed broccoli drizzled with lemon and olive oil

Friday

- Breakfast — Anti-inflammatory smoothie (frozen berries, banana, spinach, ginger, turmeric, almond milk)
- Lunch — Jacket potato with tinned tuna, sweetcorn and a mixed salad
- Dinner — Chicken stir-fry with ginger, garlic, mixed vegetables and wholemeal noodles

Weekend

- Saturday — Batch cooking day: prepare a large pot of soup or stew for the freezer. Enjoy a leisurely brunch of smoked salmon, scrambled eggs and avocado on sourdough
- Sunday — Roast chicken with roasted root vegetables (parsnips, carrots, sweet potato). Use leftovers for Monday's lunch

Quick Anti-Inflammatory Recipes

Golden Turmeric Porridge (5 minutes)

Cook 50g oats with 250ml milk or plant milk. Stir in ½ tsp turmeric, ¼ tsp cinnamon, a pinch of black pepper and 1 tsp honey. Top with walnuts and blueberries. This provides anti-inflammatory turmeric (enhanced by black pepper), omega-3 from walnuts and antioxidants from berries.

One-Tray Mediterranean Salmon (20 minutes)

Place two salmon fillets on a baking tray lined with foil. Surround with halved cherry tomatoes, sliced courgette and pitted olives. Drizzle everything with olive oil, scatter with dried oregano and squeeze over lemon juice. Bake at 200°C for 18–20 minutes. Serve with wholegrain couscous.

Simple Lentil Soup (30 minutes, serves 4)

Sauté a diced onion and 2 crushed garlic cloves in olive oil. Add 200g red lentils, a tin of chopped tomatoes, 1 litre vegetable stock, 1 tsp turmeric and 1 tsp cumin. Simmer for 25 minutes until lentils are soft. Blend if desired. Season and serve with wholemeal bread. Freezes perfectly.

Budget Tips



Openly licensed image via Openverse

- Frozen vegetables — Just as nutritious as fresh, pre-chopped and much cheaper. Frozen berries, spinach and mixed veg are staples
 - Tinned fish — Sardines, mackerel and salmon provide excellent omega-3s at a fraction of fresh fish prices
 - Dried and tinned legumes — Lentils, chickpeas and beans are cheap, nutritious and anti-inflammatory
 - Seasonal produce — Buy what's in season for better prices and fresher flavour
 - Supermarket own brands — Often identical quality to named brands at lower cost
 - Cook once, eat twice — Double batch recipes and freeze portions
-

Kitchen Adaptations for Arthritis

- Use pre-chopped frozen vegetables to avoid chopping
- A food processor handles heavy chopping tasks
- Electric tin opener eliminates painful twisting
- Lightweight pans reduce wrist strain
- Sit on a perching stool at the counter if standing is painful
- Use a kettle tipper or lightweight cordless kettle

Meal planning takes the daily decision-making stress out of eating well with arthritis. Even following these plans loosely will increase your intake of anti-inflammatory foods. Our virtual assistant can suggest more recipes based on your dietary preferences.

This article is for general information only. If you have food allergies, intolerances or are on specific medication, consult a registered dietitian for personalised advice.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about arthritis meal planning uk: weekly menus for joint health?

Short answer: An arthritis meal plan focuses on anti-inflammatory foods like vegetables, fruits, whole grains, lean protein, and healthy fats. It prioritises Omega-3s, aiming for oily fish twice weekly, and encourages colourful plates for diverse antioxidants. Practical tips include batch cooking, simple preparations to minimise hand strain, and budget-friendly choices like frozen vegetables and tinned fish.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.